DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

The Whole Book in One Evening

Derech Hashem, Siyyum

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal), with Maamar Halkarim **Section:** Maamar Halkarim, essay 10 (final paragraph), a review of the whole book, and the Siyyum **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 1 August 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

The last class of the season

The plan for the evening was to finish the tenth essay, review the essays and the main ideas of the book, make a small siyyum, and discuss what to learn next season.

The Rabbi recapped the essay on the Oral Law. It is indispensable: the written Torah is in note form, and the Oral Law explains it, elaborates on it, and sometimes reads it quite differently. The 13 principles, which we say every morning, are the tools for interpreting it. There are two kinds of asmakhta: one hangs a transmitted law, like the etrog, on a verse; the other finds a hint for a purely rabbinic law, like netilat yadayim or Hanukkah, which the Ramhal believes God intended. And last time, the Ramhal's striking view that rabbinic misvot are as binding as biblical ones, the only difference being that we are lenient in doubt.

Is the Ramhal so different?

The Rabbi said he had thought about this over the weekend, and perhaps the Ramhal is not so far from everyone else. Even the Ramhal must agree that a rabbinic sin does not carry the same punishments. No one says carrying mukseh on Shabbat carries the death penalty, as lighting a fire does. And everyone agrees that if forced to choose, you should violate the rabbinic law rather than the biblical one. The Gemara even discusses whether, when saving a life on Shabbat, one should try to do it in a rabbinic way. The answer is not to waste time on such calculations, but the concept clearly exists.

What the Ramhal insists on is that we approach rabbinic law the same way. "Has veshalom any rabbi should ever say take a rabbinic misvah less seriously." So it may be largely a matter of how it is framed.

A participant argued that the Ramhal really does hang every rabbinic law directly on "do not turn aside". The Rabbi agreed the Ramhal says so, and noted that the Gemara itself, in Shabbat 23, asks of Hanukkah candles, "where did He command us?", conceding that a rabbinic misvah stems from a biblical one. The question is how far to take it. He prefers to see "do not turn aside" as the general framework that gives the Sages their authority, not as a prohibition broken every time one handles mukseh. Otherwise every rabbinic doubt would have to be

treated strictly, and every violation would carry lashes. Perhaps, he suggested again, the Ramhal was making a point to people of his time who took rabbinic laws lightly.

Uprooting a misvah to protect the Torah

The final paragraph adds that the Sanhedrin, not the rabbis of today, has the power to uproot something in the Torah in order to preserve the Torah. But only passively: it can tell you not to do a positive misvah, never to commit a prohibition. The Rabbi's examples: the Sages said not to wear sisit in a cemetery, because it mocks the dead who can no longer keep misvot; and when Rosh Hashanah or Sukkot falls on Shabbat, we do not blow the shofar or shake the lulav, to protect Shabbat.

They could not, for example, tell someone haunted by never having tasted bacon to eat it for his peace of mind. A participant mentioned cases where something was suspended temporarily. The Rabbi explained that this is horaat shaah, a one-off measure by a recognised prophet, and that it never changes the law itself, since one of the Thirteen Principles is that the Torah is unchangeable. Saving a life is a separate matter that everyone agrees on. If we were under attack today, he said, we should keep the news on over Shabbat in case we needed to run to a shelter. "That's not a big hiddush."

Looking back on the book

The Rabbi said this is a book he has studied and taught countless times, and like many books, you only get its full potential by going over it again. He encouraged the group to revisit it, even in English: "it's not a complex book."

His key takeaways:

- **Part 1: what is God, and what am I?** The purpose of life is to cleave to God by emulating Him. Why can God not simply make us cleave to Him? Because we must be the owners of our goodness. A child trained to say thank you is not the same as someone who says it from the heart.
- **Part 2: how does God run the world?** Is there justice and a Judge? Why do the righteous suffer and the wicked prosper?
- **Part 3: how do I relate to God and the spiritual world?** The soul, dreams, Ruah HaKodesh, prophecy, and the unique prophecy of Moshe.
- **Part 4: practical life.** Why we do certain misvot at certain times, the reasons for tallit and tefillin and the rest.
- **The ten essays.** Some were revision, but some, like the tenth on rabbinic misvot, brought new light.

The group had begun in October 2020 and finished in August 2022.

What next?

The Rabbi asked for suggestions for the next season of half-hour sessions, something light enough to begin before Minhah. One participant suggested going through the Amidah blessing by blessing; the Rabbi said there is limited insight he could add beyond what is available in English, and that the kabbalistic depths of each blessing are beyond what he

could teach. Another proposed the Ramhal's Daat Tevunot, which builds on Derech Hashem as a conversation between the mind and the soul. The Rabbi said it is slightly harder but a continuation of this book, and the group agreed to begin it in September, before taking a break for the festivals. The class closed with a short siyyum.

Summary

- The Ramhal's equal status for rabbinic law may be closer to the mainstream than it seems: everyone agrees rabbinic laws must be taken seriously.
- The Sanhedrin can suspend a positive misvah to protect the Torah, but never command a sin; temporary measures need a prophet.
- Part 1 asks what God is and why we must earn closeness; Part 2 how He runs the world; Part 3 the soul and prophecy; Part 4 practical misvot.
- The essays revised the book and added new ideas, especially on the Oral Law.
- The group completed Derech Hashem after almost two years and chose Daat Tevunot for the next season.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/GZi0X6iHYi8 · More shiurim: rabbikada.com